Breath, Land, and Sovereignty

Reading Turning Stone Casino as an Indigenous Landscape

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I. Introduction

Near the curve of Exit 33, in Verona, New York, stands a presence often misunderstood. Turning Stone Resort Casino is more than just a commercial venture—it is a powerful expression of Indigenous renewal, where land, memory, and breath converge. Established by the Oneida Indian Nation in 1993, Turning Stone does not merely signify a return to ancestral territory; it represents an ongoing, active process of cultural resurgence. Its existence is rooted in the Oneida Nation's commitment to a central Haudenosaunee teaching: that decisions made today must serve not just the present, but the seventh generation to come.[1]

[1] **Haudenosaunee teaching long-term decision making**
Haudenosaunee Environmental Task Force, *Words That Come Before All Else: Environmental Philosophies of the Haudenosaunee* (Salamanca, NY: HETF, 1992) .

Caption: Turning Stone Resort Casino, a modern landmark of Oneida renewal near Exit 33 in Verona, New York.

This story does not begin with gaming machines or hotel towers; it begins with the Oneida people's enduring relationship to their land—one marked by resilience, treaty violations, resistance to removal, and the painstaking reclamation of territory. Turning Stone is not just built upon this history—it participates in the larger project of Indigenous return, visibility, and cultural continuity.[2] Each building, path, and planted field within the resort serves as an embodiment of sovereignty in action, as well as an assertion of the Oneida Nation's right to both exist and thrive on its own terms.

This paper does not aim to offer an outsider's perspective on the resort; instead, it is a narrative grounded in the lived understanding of an Indigenous scholar. The frameworks guiding this

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[2] **Oneida land reclamation treaty violations**
Jeanette Rodriguez and Ted Fortier, *Cultural Memory: Resistance, Faith, and Identity* (Austin: University of Texas Press, 2007), 77 .

research—rooted in the works of J.B. Jackson, Dell Upton, Abigail Van Slyck, and Rina Swentzell—are not tools imposed from the outside but methodological allies. Their teachings form a toolkit for reading land, law, and built environments, with the understanding that meaning is determined from within the context of the Oneida Nation's experiences.[3]

The research follows four central themes: first, how Turning Stone serves as a site of economic autonomy and spatial reclamation; second, an exploration of its architectural design and land use in light of Oneida cultural identity; third, an examination of the legal and territorial dimensions of the resort's development, particularly the land trust process and its relationship with federal and state laws; and finally, how the resort reconciles traditional values with modern enterprise, particularly through agriculture, language revitalization, and community infrastructure.[4]

This paper is not just an academic analysis but an act of personal responsibility. As a descendant of Chief Shenandoah, whose leadership was instrumental in the Oneida people's survival, I write not as an outsider but as someone rooted in the very land that now holds the community's conference centers, farms, and council rooms. This research is an act of remembering—of honoring the past and building for the future, ensuring that sovereignty continues to thrive across generations.[5]

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[3]Rina Swentzell, "Pueblo Space, Form, and Mythology," in *Pueblo Style and Regional Architecture in the Southwest*, ed. Nicholas C. Markovich, Wolfgang F.E. Preiser, and Fred G. Sturm (New York: Van Nostrand Reinhold, 1990), 41–48 .
Dell Upton, *Architecture in the United States* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998), J.B. Jackson, *Discovering the Vernacular Landscape* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1984), Abigail A. Van Slyck, *A Manufactured Wilderness: Summer Camps and the Shaping of American Youth, 1890–1960*(Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2006), 84–90 .
[4] Oneida Nation, *Turning Stone Economic Impact*, Internal Report (2023) .
Oneida Nation, *Turning Stone and Taxation*, legal brief, PDF provided by author .
[5]Oneida Indian Nation, *State Grants and Oneida Indians Exhibit*, PDF provided by author .
Laurence M. Hauptman, *The Oneida Indians in the Age of Allotment, 1860–1920* (Syracuse: Syracuse University Press, 2006), 11–15 .

II. Methodology & Theoretical Approach

This research is guided by a methodology rooted in Indigenous thought and responsibility. It privileges relationships—between land, language, governance, and memory—and approaches landscape not as neutral ground, but as an active participant in the unfolding story of a people. Drawing on traditions of Haudenosaunee knowledge and the academic tools of landscape studies, this paper examines Turning Stone not simply as a place, but as an authored expression of survival and vision. Shawn Wilson's concept of "relational accountability" emphasizes that research must be conducted in respect and service to the community, not just about it. Linda Tuhiwai Smith's work on "decolonizing methodologies" insists that knowledge production itself must be reclaimed as a space for Indigenous resistance and renewal. These approaches are not add-ons; they are the foundation of this project.[6]

At its foundation is an understanding shared across many Indigenous worldviews: that land is not passive or inert. It is animated by spirit and story, and it remembers. This view resonates with the writing of Tewa scholar and architect Rina Swentzell, who saw the built environment not as a medium of control, but of relationship. For Swentzell, architecture should reflect harmony with land and life, and her assertion that "to breathe is to learn" informs the use of spatial design as pedagogy throughout this analysis.[7]

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[6] Shawn Wilson, *Research Is Ceremony: Indigenous Research Methods* (Halifax: Fernwood Publishing, 2008), 56–60; Linda Tuhiwai Smith, *Decolonizing Methodologies: Research and Indigenous Peoples*, 2nd ed. (London: Zed Books, 2012), 20–25.

[7] Rina Swentzell, "Pueblo Space, Form, and Mythology," in *Pueblo Style and Regional Architecture in the Southwest*, ed. Nicholas C. Markovich, Wolfgang F.E. Preiser, and Fred G. Sturm (New York: Van Nostrand Reinhold, 1990), 41–48.

To read Turning Stone as a layered spatial narrative, the research also draws on J.B. Jackson's concept of vernacular landscape—spaces shaped by cultural meaning as much as by formal design. Jackson's idea that landscapes are "history made visible" validates a close reading of features often overlooked in architectural scholarship: signage, paths, room names, materials, and adjacency.[8]These elements speak to intention, and to a politics of presence. I have long considered this the delight of the vernacular—a term that, for me, captures how ordinary structures can hold extraordinary cultural and political meaning.

Dell Upton's work adds a further dimension: power. He urges readers to understand architecture as a materialization of law, governance, and resistance. His emphasis on the spatial consequences of legal and social structures supports the analysis of Turning Stone's legal geography, particularly its placement on federal trust land and its design as a visible, accessible assertion of Oneida jurisdiction and economic strength.[9]

Abigail Van Slyck offers a pedagogical lens. Her research on institutional environments—particularly her critique of "Indian camps" created by white reformers—demonstrates how space can instruct and distort. Her work helps to frame Turning Stone as a counter-narrative: a built environment that does not simulate Native culture but embodies it through control, authorship, and rooted presence.[10]

These frameworks are not imposed upon the project from a distance. They are brought into conversation with Indigenous scholarly practices, especially the principles outlined by Shawn Wilson (relational accountability) and Linda Tuhiwai Smith (decolonizing methodology).

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[8] J.B. Jackson, *Discovering the Vernacular Landscape* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1984), 1.
[9] Dell Upton, *Architecture in the United States* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998), 9–12.
[10] Abigail A. Van Slyck, *A Manufactured Wilderness: Summer Camps and the Shaping of American Youth, 1890–1960*(Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2006), 84–90.

Wilson's belief that knowledge must be in service to community, and Smith's call to reclaim research as a space of resistance, shape every layer of inquiry here—from archive selection to landscape interpretation.

As someone who carries the name Shenandoah, this project is more than academic. It is also an act of continuation. The name bears a legacy of leadership and diplomacy, and it anchors this research in personal accountability to land, community, and future. Methodology here is not merely analytical; it is lived and relational.

Primary sources include Oneida Nation documents, tribal and regional news archives, Bureau of Indian Affairs records, maps, legal filings, and first-person observation. These are not used to confirm theory but to reveal meaning. Their interpretation is guided by both scholarship and story, by the authority of place, and by the breath of a Nation still building.

III. Cultural Identity and the Built Environment

The design and materiality of Turning Stone's structures are not incidental; they reflect intentional acts of cultural authorship. Where settler resorts often appropriate Indigenous motifs as aesthetic surface, the Oneida Nation embeds cultural meaning into the architecture itself. Nowhere is this more evident than in The Lodge and the Skʌ:nʌ́: Spa, where architectural language translates values of welcome, peace, and healing into form.

Caption: Interior of The Lodge at Turning Stone, reflecting Haudenosaunee architectural and cultural values.

The Lodge, with its timber columns, earth-toned palette, and curving, organic layout, evokes the ethos of the Haudenosaunee longhouse. This is not mimicry, but continuity. The longhouse, central to Haudenosaunee political and cultural life, is not merely a structure—it is a worldview. The very name "Haudenosaunee" translates as "People of the Longhouse," referencing not only the form but the function: shelter, governance, kinship, and unity. The spatial rhythm of The Lodge—with its horizontal emphasis, communal seating, and hearth-like interiors—reflects these principles, translating kinship into architectural form.[11]

This relationship between design and cultural worldview is deepened by the strategic use of language throughout the resort. The spa is named Skʌ:nʌ́:, meaning "peace" in Oneida. Event

[11] Rina Swentzell, "Pueblo Space, Form, and Mythology," in *Pueblo Style and Regional Architecture in the Southwest*, ed. Nicholas C. Markovich, Wolfgang F.E. Preiser, and Fred G. Sturm (New York: Van Nostrand Reinhold, 1990), 46.

rooms and corridors bear the names of the Six Nations of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy: Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, Seneca, and Tuscarora. These are not symbolic gestures; they are spatial assertions of sovereignty. As linguist Margaret Noori has written, public use of Indigenous language in built environments reclaims not only cultural meaning but cognitive space—replacing colonial silence with Indigenous presence.[12]

Language here does not merely label—it instructs. To see Skʌ:nʌ́: printed on a sign, or to walk through a hallway named for a Haudenosaunee nation, is to encounter a worldview. As Rina Swentzell stated, "to breathe is to learn." In this context, breath is not just life—it is pedagogy.[13]These spaces teach not through plaques or exhibitions, but through spatial immersion.

The Shenendoah Clubhouse takes this principle further. Sited just beyond the main resort and adjacent to the golf course, it blends hospitality with homage. Its low, grounded profile and expansive glass walls open to the landscape, creating a visual and spatial dialogue with the surrounding land. Inside, exposed timber, open circulation, and communal spaces reflect Haudenosaunee values of gathering and relationality.

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[12] Margaret Noori, quoted in related discussions on Indigenous language and space (context from user-provided sources).
[13] Swentzell, "Pueblo Space, Form, and Mythology," 48.

Caption: The Shenendoah Clubhouse, named for Chief Shenandoah, stands as a site of memory and gathering.

Named in honor of Chief Shenandoah—a revered leader who helped guide the Oneida through the Revolutionary War and maintain the Covenant Chain of diplomacy—the Clubhouse becomes an act of architectural memory. As Dell Upton reminds us, buildings can materialize political power and historical presence.[14]Here, naming is not commemoration; it is continuity. For a visitor, the name may signal welcome. For me, it is a reminder of responsibility.

This architectural narrative actively resists the visual tropes common in many tribal enterprises—feathers, tipis, pan-Indian motifs designed for settler legibility. At Turning Stone, identity is not performed; it is lived. Cultural representation is not nostalgic—it is contemporary, situated, and self-authored. It does not explain itself to outsiders. It asserts itself to descendants.

Where settler colonial maps once divided this land into plots, Turning Stone now overlays meaning through spatial design. Rooms, pathways, materials, and names work in tandem to

[14] Dell Upton, *Architecture in the United States* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998), 11–12.

create a built environment that teaches, honors, and breathes. The result is a landscape of presence—one that insists not only on survival, but on authorship.

IV. Legal Context and Historical Background

Turning Stone Resort Casino stands at the intersection of law, land, and sovereignty. The Oneida Nation's relationship with its land has been defined by centuries of contested jurisdiction, treaty violations, and shifting federal and state policies. To understand the legal and spatial dimensions of Turning Stone, it is crucial to explore the historical backdrop of Oneida land claims, beginning with the 1794 Treaty of Canandaigua.[15]

The Treaty of Canandaigua, ratified by the U.S. government, recognized the Oneida Nation's territorial rights and promised to secure their lands. Despite this promise, New York State continued to acquire Oneida land without federal consent, in violation of the 1790 Trade and Intercourse Act.[16] This violation triggered a long-standing dispute over the Nation's ancestral lands. By the mid-20th century, the Oneida Nation had lost nearly all of its original six million acres, leaving only a small fraction of their territory intact.

The Oneida Nation's legal battles to reclaim its land began to gain momentum in the 1970s and 1980s. The landmark 1985 Supreme Court case *Oneida County v. Oneida Indian Nation* was a turning point, affirming that counties could be held liable for damages resulting from unlawful land transactions.[17] However, legal victories met with setbacks in the early 2000s. The 2005 *City*

[15] Treaty of Canandaigua, Nov. 11, 1794, 7 Stat. 44 Untitled document-7.
[16] "State Grants and Oneida Indians Exhibit," Oneida Nation Archives, accessed April 2025, PDF provided by authorUntitled document-7.

[17] *Oneida County v. Oneida Indian Nation*, 470 U.S. 226 (1985)Untitled document-7.

of Sherrill v. Oneida Indian Nation decision further complicated the Nation's efforts by ruling that the Oneida Nation could not restore sovereignty over reacquired lands without undergoing the federal trust process.[18]

Trust Land and Sovereignty

In response to the *Sherrill* decision, the Oneida Nation sought to place over 13,000 acres, including the land on which Turning Stone sits, into federal trust. The federal trust process provided significant protections, including exemptions from state and local taxation and recognition of the Oneida's jurisdictional authority.[19] This decision represented a crucial victory, but it was met with strong opposition from local municipalities, which feared the loss of tax revenue and planning control.

Legal challenges from local governments to the Oneida Nation's trust lands were dismissed, reinforcing the Nation's right to self-governance. However, these legal disputes underscored the continuing resistance to Indigenous sovereignty in upstate New York. Despite these challenges, the Oneida Nation's determination to secure its legal and territorial rights remains unwavering.

The placement of Turning Stone within federal trust land is more than a legal technicality; it is a physical manifestation of sovereignty. As legal scholar Sarah Krakoff asserts, "sovereignty lives in land."[20] The establishment of trust land confirms the Oneida Nation's right to govern its territory, control its resources, and enact its political and cultural vision. The legal geography of Turning Stone, including its design and location, reflects the Nation's commitment to reasserting sovereignty over its ancestral territory.

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[18] *City of Sherrill v. Oneida Indian Nation of New York*, 544 U.S. 197 (2005)Untitled document-7.
[19] "Turning Stone and Taxation," Oneida Nation Legal Brief, accessed April 2025, PDF provided by author
[20] Sarah Krakoff, "Tribes, Land, and Environment," in *Tribes, Land, and Environment*, ed. Ezra Rosser and Sarah Krakoff (Farnham, UK: Ashgate, 2012), 3–22

Broader Implications for Indigenous Land Rights

Turning Stone's legal victory is not an isolated case. The Oneida Nation's experience highlights the broader challenges faced by Indigenous nations across the U.S. In many instances, federal policies have created a precarious landscape of legal uncertainty, where land rights and jurisdictional authority are constantly contested. For example, the Mashpee Wampanoag Tribe of Massachusetts faced a similar struggle with the revocation of its trust lands in 2020.[21]This ongoing struggle for jurisdiction and land security is part of a larger context of legal battles that shape Indigenous land tenure across the country.

Turning Stone serves as a model for other tribes seeking to assert their sovereignty in the face of legal and political opposition. The Oneida Nation's ability to secure federal trust status for its land and negotiate a settlement agreement with local governments demonstrates the power of persistence and legal strategy. The 2013 Settlement Agreement between the Oneida Nation, New York State, and surrounding counties affirmed the resort's trust status and created a framework for cooperative governance and revenue-sharing.[22]

This agreement not only settled long-standing legal disputes but also reaffirmed the Oneida Nation's right to govern its land. It established a model of coexistence, albeit one shaped by power imbalances. Through this legal process, Turning Stone becomes more than a business—it embodies the resilience of the Oneida Nation's legal and political strategy.

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[21] Michael Powell, "David and Goliath: Sherrill, N.Y., and the Oneida Indian Nation," *The New York Times*, July 2, 2005

[22] "Turning Stone Economic Impact," Oneida Nation Enterprises, 2023. PDF provided by author

V. Architecture and Law: A Material Expression of Sovereignty

The architecture of Turning Stone, as Dell Upton argues, is not politically neutral. It reflects and enacts relations of power. The scale of the resort, its placement on federal trust land, and the visibility of its design from the New York Thruway all perform sovereignty in space. The resort's entranceways, parking structures, and signage are not merely functional; they serve as constant reminders of the Oneida Nation's authority over its territory.

In this sense, Turning Stone's architecture is a direct response to the legal constraints imposed by centuries of colonialism. It asserts that sovereignty is not just a matter of legal status—it is a material, spatial practice. Every expansion, every new building, and every sign placed within the resort reinforces the Oneida Nation's claim to self-governance and self-determination.

Turning Stone's success as a legal and architectural symbol of sovereignty extends beyond the resort itself. It becomes a site where legal theory and tribal governance converge, reshaping the narrative around Indigenous land rights. The visibility of the resort, both physically and legally, serves as a counter-archive to centuries of dispossession, marking a place where sovereignty is enacted and made visible.

VI. Cultural Programming and Language Revitalization

Beyond its gaming floor and luxury amenities, Turning Stone Resort Casino plays a vital role in the Oneida Nation's broader cultural renaissance. The resort serves as a living space where language, history, and Indigenous knowledge systems are not just preserved but actively practiced, reshaping public perceptions and reinforcing the Nation's sovereignty. Language revitalization, as one of the primary components of this process, is not just a cultural effort—it is a direct challenge to the historic erasure of Indigenous knowledge and identity.

Language as a Pillar of Sovereignty

The Oneida language, like many Indigenous languages, has suffered from centuries of colonization, forced assimilation, and residential schools that sought to extinguish it. The resurgence of the Oneida language is not simply a nostalgic reclamation of the past but a contemporary act of cultural and political resistance. Language is central to Indigenous self-determination; it is not just a means of communication but the vehicle through which cultural knowledge, traditions, and worldviews are transmitted across generations. For the Oneida Nation, the active promotion and revitalization of their language at Turning Stone is part of a larger effort to assert sovereignty, independence, and control over their cultural narrative.

Turning Stone's commitment to language revitalization is evident in how the Oneida language is embedded throughout the resort. From signage to room names to menus, Oneida words such as *Skʌ:nʌ́:* for peace and *Yawʌʔko* for thank you are presented to guests not merely as cultural decorations, but as living elements of the Oneida worldview. These displays represent a pedagogical strategy, as scholar Margaret Noori suggests, where the everyday visibility of Indigenous languages in public spaces challenges colonial silences and reclaims cognitive space once lost to policies of forced assimilation.[23] At Turning Stone, visitors are not only seeing the language; they are experiencing it, interacting with it, and perhaps even learning it in real-time. This practice goes beyond symbolic representation—it is a practical manifestation of language as cultural power.

Cultural Pedagogy Through Architecture

[23] Margaret Noori, "Waasamoogkag: Shining Light on Native Language Renewal," *Studies in American Indian Literatures*19, no. 1 (2007): 87

Rina Swentzell, a Tewa architect and scholar, writes that "to breathe is to learn." In the context of Turning Stone, this is not only about physical breath but the symbolic breath that cultural spaces give to language, stories, and people. Swentzell's notion suggests that architecture itself has the capacity to teach, and the design of Turning Stone reflects this teaching role. The design of spaces like the *Skʌ:nʌ́:* Spa and The Lodge does not only accommodate guests but invites them to connect with the Oneida people's worldview. The curves, earth-toned color schemes, and natural materials evoke a sense of harmony with the land, a key principle in Oneida teachings. The integration of language within these spaces, through names and signage, brings visitors into direct contact with the cultural values that shape these environments. It transforms the resort from a tourist attraction into an immersive learning environment where guests are invited into the broader narrative of Indigenous resurgence.

The architecture of Turning Stone itself is a form of cultural pedagogy. It teaches through its spatial design—each room and space embedded with meaning that challenges both visitors and community members to engage with the Indigenous presence in the landscape. For instance, the use of materials like wood, stone, and earth tones in the Shenendoah Clubhouse reflects a relationship to the land that the Oneida people have maintained for centuries. The large windows and open spaces create a sense of connection with the surrounding natural world, mirroring the Oneida people's deeply rooted philosophy of respect and reciprocity with the land.

Cultural Programming: Bridging Generations

Cultural programming at Turning Stone serves not only as a vehicle for preserving Oneida traditions but also for actively engaging younger generations and non-Native visitors alike. One of the most significant aspects of this programming is its ability to bridge generational gaps and

facilitate intergenerational transmission of knowledge. This is accomplished through a variety of activities and events that are designed to both preserve and revitalize traditional practices while adapting them to contemporary contexts.

The Oneida Heritage Center plays a pivotal role in this effort, serving as both a community archive and a public learning space. Its exhibits recount the history of the Oneida people, the importance of clan governance, and the ceremonial practices that have sustained the Nation for generations.[24] But the Heritage Center does more than preserve history—it actively engages visitors, both Native and non-Native, in a dialogue about Oneida culture and sovereignty. This space reflects a broader pedagogical approach—as Rina Swentzell suggested, cultural practices must be continuously lived and practiced, not merely remembered.[25] The Heritage Center facilitates this living, ongoing practice by providing a place where Oneida youth can learn about their heritage, and non-Native guests can engage with it.

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[24] Oneida Indian Nation, *ProQuest Documents – Oneida Heritage and Educational Initiatives*, PDF provided by author

[25] Rina Swentzell, "To Live as a People," in *The People and the Word: Reading Native Nonfiction*, ed. Robert Warrior (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2005), 109

Caption:Market/exhibits at the Oneida Heritage Center, where history and identity converge.

In addition to the Heritage Center, seasonal events like the Haudenosaunee Art Market and Indigenous Peoples' Day celebrations provide public opportunities for the Oneida Nation to showcase its cultural resilience. These events go beyond simple displays of art or performances—they are interactive experiences that invite the broader community to engage in the Nation's cultural practices. Through storytelling, wampum making, and traditional dance performances, the Oneida Nation fosters a deeper understanding of its ongoing presence and cultural strength. As Rina Swentzell's work suggests, these cultural practices are not frozen in time but are evolving, lived experiences that continue to shape the future of the Nation.

Caption:Market/exhibits at the Oneida Heritage Center, where history and identity converge.

Reinforcing Sovereignty Through Language and Culture

At the core of Turning Stone's cultural programming is the principle of sovereignty through education. Language classes, youth programs, and traditional craft workshops are funded by the casino's revenue, ensuring that the wealth generated by the resort is reinvested into the Oneida community. These initiatives are not simply about preserving culture for the sake of nostalgia—they are a direct assertion of Indigenous self-determination and a refusal to let history erase the Oneida people's identity. These programs allow the Nation to build infrastructure for its own cultural revitalization—to create spaces where language, knowledge, and tradition are practiced and passed down without the interference of external forces.

By embedding language and cultural practices into the very fabric of the resort, the Oneida Nation asserts that sovereignty is not only a political or legal claim; it is a lived reality that is enacted daily, in every interaction, every program, and every space. Turning Stone, as both a resort and a cultural institution, demonstrates that sovereignty is not abstract—it is enacted in the

tangible spaces that one inhabits. The integration of language and culture into these spaces ensures that Turning Stone is not simply a commercial site but a vector for the continued thriving of the Oneida Nation, where sovereignty is lived, taught, and sustained across generations.

VII. Agriculture and Food Sovereignty

The landscape surrounding Turning Stone Resort Casino is not merely ornamental; it serves as a critical site of cultural resurgence and self-determination. The Oneida Nation's agricultural initiatives play a central role in this broader project of cultural revitalization and sovereignty. Through the management of over 8,000 acres of farmland, the Nation not only reaffirms its cultural and historical ties to the land but also challenges colonial food systems that have historically undermined Indigenous autonomy. This section explores how the Oneida Nation's agricultural programming at Turning Stone reflects their commitment to food sovereignty, a principle that empowers communities to reclaim control over their food systems in alignment with traditional values and ecological sustainability.[26]

Reclaiming the Land through Agriculture

Agriculture for the Oneida Nation is more than just an economic endeavor; it is a way to reclaim their relationship to the land—a relationship that was systematically disrupted by colonialism and forced assimilation. The Oneida Nation's commitment to agricultural renewal is an act of decolonization, as it resists industrialized food systems that promote dependence on non-Indigenous economic models. By cultivating crops like heirloom white corn, the Nation

[26] Oneida Indian Nation, *Where Profit and Tradition Mingle*, The New York Times, PDF provided by author .

reconnects with its ancestral agricultural practices, which are deeply embedded in its cultural and spiritual traditions.[27]

The revival of heirloom white corn—the same variety that Oneida matriarchs carried to Washington's starving army at Valley Forge—is not just an economic act but a symbolic reclamation of Indigenous food sovereignty.[28] This specific strain of corn, once central to the Oneida's agricultural system, is not only used for daily sustenance but also for ceremonial purposes, reconnecting the Nation to its ancestral practices.[29] The revival of this corn reflects the Oneida's efforts to restore traditional food systems that align with both ecological sustainability and cultural survival.

At Turning Stone, this corn appears on the plates of guests at the resort's restaurants, such as the TS Steakhouse and Wildflowers, where it is incorporated into both fine dining and traditional dishes. The use of heirloom white corn in this context highlights the way Turning Stone bridges the gap between cultural preservation and modern commerce.[30] It is not just a culinary experience; it is a pedagogical experience—one that teaches guests about the significance of food within the Oneida worldview. As the food moves from the fields to the plates, it carries with it a message of sovereignty and resilience, ensuring that the Oneida Nation's culinary traditions are not merely a relic of the past but a living, thriving part of contemporary Indigenous life.

Ecological Sustainability

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[27] Jim Adams, "Oneida, N.Y.-Area Farm Fosters Culture, Profit," *Indian Country Today*, June 9, 2004, PDF provided by author .
[28] Oneida Indian Nation, "Once Destitute, Oneida Tribe Builds a New Economy," *The New York Times*, PDF provided by author .
[29] Brian Patterson, quoted in Adams, "Oneida, N.Y.-Area Farm Fosters Culture, Profit" .
[30] Oneida Nation Agriculture Brochure, PDF provided by author .

The Oneida Nation's agricultural initiatives at Turning Stone are also deeply connected to ecological sustainability. The practice of food sovereignty, as defined by scholars like Winona LaDuke, goes beyond ensuring food security—it embodies the right of communities to define their own food systems, based on cultural knowledge and sustainable environmental practices.[31]For the Oneida Nation, this means growing food in harmony with the land and ensuring that agricultural practices are both culturally appropriate and ecologically sustainable.[32]

Through initiatives such as the cultivation of corn alongside other traditional crops like beans and squash—known as the Three Sisters—the Nation honors traditional ecological knowledge that has been passed down for generations.[33]These crops, planted in symbiotic relationships with each other, reflect the Oneida's broader philosophy of reciprocity and interconnectedness with the land. This method, which utilizes natural ecological cycles, ensures that the soil remains fertile and that agricultural practices do not degrade the environment but rather nurture it.

Beyond corn, the Oneida Nation also manages a Black Angus cattle herd, which supplies beef to the resort's restaurants, creating a closed-loop agricultural system.[34] This system not only supports food sovereignty but also reinforces the Nation's economic independence. By controlling the production and distribution of both plant-based and animal products, the Oneida Nation reduces its reliance on outside suppliers, thereby strengthening its position within both the regional economy and local food systems.[35] This model of territorial embeddedness ensures

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[31] Winona LaDuke, *Recovering the Sacred: The Power of Naming and Claiming*, cited in PDF materials provided by author.
[32] Oneida Indian Nation Agriculture Brochure, PDF provided by author.
[33] Adams, "Oneida, N.Y.-Area Farm Fosters Culture, Profit."
[34] Oneida Indian Nation, *Where Profit and Tradition Mingle*.

[35] "Once Destitute, Oneida Tribe Builds a New Economy," *The New York Times*.

that the economic benefits generated by the resort stay within the Oneida community, providing resources for both economic development and cultural preservation.[36]

VI. Community Empowerment

Food sovereignty is not only about the cultivation of crops; it is also about the empowerment of the community. The Oneida Nation's agricultural programs provide opportunities for youth education and workforce development, teaching younger generations both the practical skills needed for farming and the broader cultural teachings embedded in traditional ecological knowledge. Through programs that teach farming techniques, soil health, and sustainable land management, the Oneida Nation is investing in its future, ensuring that next generations have the tools they need to continue the work of land stewardship and food sovereignty.[37]

These educational programs also extend into the broader community, with outreach initiatives that introduce the public to Indigenous agricultural practices and their relevance to contemporary food systems. Seasonal gatherings, such as those that feature produce from Oneida farms, help educate both the community and visitors about the significance of Indigenous food systems, reinforcing the Nation's sovereignty and cultural continuity.[38] These programs embody the principle that food is not just sustenance but a vehicle for cultural continuity—and that sovereignty is realized not only through legal means but through cultural practices, including the reclamation of food systems.

Turning Stone as a Model of Relational Economy

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[36] Oneida Nation Agriculture Brochure.
[37] Oneida Nation, "Turning Stone Economic Impact," Internal Report, PDF provided by authorUntitled document-7.
[38] Ibid.

Turning Stone's agricultural initiatives serve as a model of what some scholars call a relational economy—one where economic practices are embedded in community and environmental well-being.[39] The success of the Oneida Nation's food sovereignty initiatives reflects a comprehensive approach to self-determination, where agriculture, hospitality, community education, and cultural preservation reinforce one another. This integrated system ensures that the economic benefits of the resort are shared with the community, strengthening not only the Nation's financial standing but also its cultural and environmental resilience.

As a part of this model, the Nation has also undertaken efforts to reduce its environmental footprint. The decision to grow food and raise livestock locally reduces the environmental costs associated with importing food from distant suppliers, contributing to a more sustainable food system. It also allows the Oneida Nation to reclaim control over its food chain, reducing its dependence on external economic forces that have historically placed Indigenous communities at a disadvantage.[40] This form of economic sovereignty aligns with wider efforts across Indian Country, where Indigenous nations are increasingly asserting control over their natural resources and economies.

Beyond the Casino: Agricultural as a Cultural Act

It is important to note that the agricultural programming at Turning Stone is not merely a business strategy—it is a cultural act that reflects the Oneida Nation's broader goals of resurgence and renewal. Just as architecture at Turning Stone expresses cultural identity, the agricultural programs contribute to the political expression of sovereignty. Agriculture at Turning Stone is not simply a means of generating income; it is a continuation of the relationship the

[39] Ibid.
[40] Winona LaDuke, *Recovering the Sacred: The Power of Naming and Claiming* (Cambridge, MA: South End Press, 2005

Oneida people have had with their land for millennia.[41] It is a reminder that Indigenous peoples are not passive victims of colonialism but active agents in shaping their futures.

Through the reclamation of agricultural practices, the Oneida Nation is not only rebuilding its cultural identity but also reasserting its right to exist in a political and economic landscape that has too often marginalized and erased its presence. Turning Stone's agricultural initiatives represent the Nation's refusal to be defined by the colonial narratives of erasure. Instead, they write their own story—one rooted in the land, in self-sufficiency, and in sovereignty.

VII. Breath, Land, and Presence

Turning Stone Resort Casino is not just a leisure destination—it is a symbol of resilience, renewal, and sovereignty. Its architecture, land, and economic functions tell a story of persistence, where every brick laid and every corner turned reflects a commitment to Indigenous self-determination. Through its creation, the Oneida Nation has reclaimed not only land but also a sense of purpose and presence in the wider political and cultural landscape.

As a descendant of Chief Shenandoah, whose leadership helped guide our people through the tumultuous challenges of the past, I feel deeply connected to the work that has gone into the realization of Turning Stone. My name is not just a reminder of history but a call to action—to continue the legacy of diplomacy, resilience, and cultural endurance. Chief Shenandoah's legacy was not only about surviving but also about thriving. That legacy is woven into the very fabric of the Oneida Nation's work today, and through projects like Turning Stone, we are not simply remembering the past—we are building for the future.[42]

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[41] Jim Adams, "Oneida, N.Y.-Area Farm Fosters Culture, Profit," *Indian Country Today*
[42] Oneida Indian Nation, *"State Grants and Oneida Indians Exhibit,"* PDF provided by author

The land remembers. It holds the stories of those who have walked upon it and continues to bear witness to the work of those who fight for their rightful place in the world. The effort to return, to reassert sovereignty, is not a task for one generation, but a responsibility passed down. Just as my ancestors carried corn to Washington's starving troops at Valley Forge, today's efforts carry the weight of history, but they also lay the foundation for generations to come.[43] Turning Stone is part of that future-building process, a space that does not just support economic growth but also fosters cultural revitalization and intergenerational knowledge.

This paper has explored how the Oneida Nation uses Turning Stone as a means of economic, cultural, and political reclamation. But it is also a testament to the power of cultural continuity, to the role of the land in holding stories and shaping futures. Turning Stone is not simply a casino; it is a space where culture, language, and identity are asserted, taught, and lived. It is a model for other Indigenous nations, showing that sovereignty is not only a legal or political status—it is a lived experience, a constant work of engagement with land, law, and culture.

Looking ahead, Turning Stone stands as a beacon of what is possible when Indigenous nations reclaim their sovereignty—when they not only survive but thrive. The success of Turning Stone is more than just an economic victory; it is part of a larger movement that is reshaping the relationship between Native nations and the state. As we move forward, the lessons of Turning Stone will continue to inform not only the Oneida Nation but also the broader Indigenous sovereignty movement across the U.S. The future is not a passive inheritance but a space we actively shape, one where we reclaim our stories, our spaces, and our futures for the generations still to come.

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[43] *Historical Timeline of the Oneida Indian Nation,* PDF provided by author